

2026 IBMer watsonx Challenge

OFFICIAL RULES

NO PURCHASE OR PAYMENT NECESSARY TO ENTER OR WIN. VOID WHERE PROHIBITED. ENTRY IN THIS CONTEST CONSTITUTES YOUR AGREEMENT TO BE BOUND BY THESE OFFICIAL RULES.

The **2026 IBMer watsonx Challenge** (the “Contest”) is a hands-on learning experience and challenge. IBM Corporation (“IBM” or “Sponsor”) will select the winning entries and prizes will be awarded under these Official Rules (the “Rules”).

By participating in the Contest, you, as the “Participant” agree to be bound by these 2026 IBMer watsonx Challenge Official Rules (“Official Rules”) and all Contest related communications from the Sponsors (including its authorized representatives and organizers) in any and all media/medium, and the decisions of the Sponsor and Judges (including their authorized representatives) which are final and binding in all respects.

1. Binding Agreement. To enter the Contest, you must agree to the Rules. Therefore, please read these Rules before entry to ensure you understand and agree. You agree that submission of an entry in the Contest constitutes agreement to these Rules. You may not submit an entry to the Contest and are not eligible to receive the prizes described in these Rules unless you agree to these Rules. These Rules are a binding legal agreement between you and IBM with respect to the Contest.

2. Eligibility. Participation is only open to Eligible Employees (defined below), who are legal residents of the country in which they reside and are at least 18 years of age and the age of majority in their country, state, province, and/or city of residence. All IBMers are eligible to participate in the challenge. This does not include employees of excluded subsidiaries who are not eligible to receive prizes, freelancers, or independent contractors. If you are eligible for overtime or additional compensation (i.e., weekend premiums), you need to have manager approval prior to participating. IBM Executives are eligible to participate in the challenge individually or as part of a team, however they are not eligible for any Prizes (defined below). Members of the IBMer watsonx Challenge planning teams are eligible to participate in the challenge individually or as part of a team, however they are not eligible for any Prizes (defined below). Any Eligible Employees who leave Sponsor's employ or terminate their relationship at any time before the awarding of a prize (if applicable) for any reason are no longer eligible and forfeit any prizes and all Contest rights and eligibility. Verification of employment will be reviewed by the Sponsor, and any decision related to eligibility will be at its sole discretion. This Contest is governed exclusively by the laws of the United States. All federal, state, and local laws and regulations apply. Void where prohibited, taxed or restricted by law. IBMers in countries (China, Hong Kong, Russian federation, Venezuela) where IBM Bob is not available will not be able to access or use IBM Bob for the challenge.

3. Sponsor. The Contest is sponsored by IBM Corporation, 1 New Orchard Road, Armonk, New York 10504, United States.

4. Contest Entry Period.

The Contest begins on July 8, 2026, at or around 10:00 AM Eastern Time (ET) in the United States and ends on July 22, 2026, at or around 10:00 AM Eastern Time (ET) (the “Contest Entry Period”). The selection of qualifying “Competitive Submissions” to move on to final round judging will occur no later than two weeks after the end of the Contest Entry Period.

All dates are subject to change.

5. Contest Objective. Teams of 1 – 10 will submit a concept using IBM Bob to address a specific problem. For teams submitting to the Consulting Business Area, the submission can use IBM Bob and/or IBM Consulting Advantage (Participants in countries without access to IBM Bob will use an alternate AI tool).

6. How to Enter. NO PURCHASE NECESSARY TO ENTER OR WIN. To enter and register the Contest, visit the [IBMer watsonx Challenge page](#), during the Contest Entry Period, read these Official Rules, and follow the instructions that appear on the Contest instructions page.

7. All entry materials become the sole and exclusive property of the Sponsor and receipt of entries will not be acknowledged or returned. Sponsor is not responsible for lost, late, illegible, stolen, incomplete, invalid, unintelligible, misdirected, technically corrupted or garbled entries, which will be disqualified, or for problems of any kind whether mechanical, human or electronic. Only fully completed entries are eligible. Proof of submission will not be deemed to be proof of receipt by Sponsor.

8. Submission Requirements. Winning teams are required to complete required education plan and submit the deliverables as specified.

Required education will be available on “Your Learning at IBM” and must be completed before submissions close on July 22, 2026, at 10:00 AM ET. Required education is defined as:

- All IBMers must complete the education at <https://yourlearning.ibm.com/activity/PLAN-3067F00C01E4>.
- Consulting IBMers must additionally complete the education at <https://yourlearning.ibm.com/activity/PLAN-20442493D331>.

Descriptions of each deliverable will be listed on the IBMer watsonx Challenge website (<https://w3.ibm.com/w3publisher/challenge>) once the Contest begins. Deliverables must be submitted before the end of the Contest July 22, 2026, at 10:00 AM ET.

You acknowledge and understand that the Sponsors may use your Submission for promotional opportunities, including in promotional activities, public announcements, media events, or other marketing opportunities, specifically as it relates to your participation in the IBMer watsonx Challenge, without further notification, permission, or compensation.

You further acknowledge and affirm that the ownership of your Submission is governed by terms and conditions of your Agreement Regarding Confidential Information, Intellectual Property and Other Matters or any predecessor agreement you have signed to which you have agreed and do agree.

You affirm that you own or have valid license rights or permission to use any Technology (as defined below) included in your Submission.

You affirm that any Submission to the “IBMer watsonx Challenge” will be original work that was substantially developed between July 8, 2026, at 10:00 AM ET and July 22, 2026, at 10:00 AM ET.

To submit a competitive Submission for judging, participants must indicate that they want their Submission judged and select a Business Area judging committee. Teams that indicate they do not want their Submission sent to judging will not proceed through the judging process and will not be eligible for prizes.

9. Judging. All submissions will first go through an AI evaluation of completeness and eligibility to be recommended as a competitive Submission to move on for judging. A panel of judges will evaluate each competitive Submission using a combination of judging criteria as described in this section, based on a scoring rubric. Notwithstanding the foregoing, the Sponsors may reject any Submission that does not satisfy the objective of the Event in the Sponsors’ discretion. Any such decision is final and not subject to appeal.

Each competitive Submission will be scored based on the following criteria, with the final score being the average of the judges’ scores and an assessment of:

- Practicality and coherence
- Effectiveness and efficiency
- Design and usability
- Creativity and innovation

Judges for IBMer watsonx Challenge will be selected from a diverse set of subject matter experts in the fields of technology and other appropriate areas.

A judge may elect to recuse him or herself from evaluating a Submission, or the Sponsor may require a judge to recuse him or herself from evaluating a Submission, if, in the judge’s or a Sponsor’s discretion, it would not be appropriate for the judge to evaluate a participant’s Submission because of a past or current relationship with the participant. Recusal decisions are final and not subject to appeal.

10. Prizes.

Subject to receiving sufficient eligible entries, prize(s) available to be awarded in the contest are as follows:

Winning teams from each Business Area:

- First place
 - 1000 BluePoints per team member
- Second place
 - 500 BluePoints per team member

A total of six first and six second place awards, one per Business Area, will be given based on executive judging selection where legally permitted.

Special recognition:

- Chairman's award
- Second runner-up team
- Third runner-up team
- All three (3) special recognition teams get 1 ticket per team member to IBM Tech (Travel to be funded by Business Area)
- Top two (2) special recognition teams get 1 ticket per team member to IBM TechXchange 2026 conference October 26-29, 2026, Atlanta, Georgia (Tickets are subject to legal pre-approval and are non-transferable, Travel to be funded by Business Area)

Prizes are non-transferable. No substitutions for winners. However, in the case of unavailability of any prize, IBM reserves the right to substitute a prize of equal or greater value. The Sponsor reserves the right, at its sole discretion, to modify, supplement, or expand the forms of special recognition awarded to participants. This may include, but is not limited to, the provision of additional recognition prizes or awards to teams based on criteria determined solely by the Sponsor.

Any and all federal, state, provincial and local taxes are the sole responsibility of the winners. All expenses not specifically listed herein are the responsibility of winners. The value of BluePoints is subject to taxation and/or payroll reporting in most countries, however tax assistance will be provided for all BluePoints. The value of any BluePoints you receive will be included in your taxable income, but IBM will compensate you for those taxes with a tax assistance payment.

If selected, winners agree to participate in public relations events or interviews, as determined by IBM in its sole and absolute discretion. Winners may be required to sign and return, an Affidavit or Declaration of Eligibility and Liability/Publicity Release ("Release") (where legal) in the time frame designated by IBM.

11. Notification. Potential winners will be notified by email within approximately twenty-four (24) hours after selection. If any potential winner cannot be contacted within two (2) calendar days of first notification attempt, if any prize or prize notification is returned as undeliverable, if any potential winner rejects his/her prize or in the event of noncompliance with these Contest rules and requirements, such prize will be forfeited and may be awarded to an alternate (time permitting). Upon prize forfeiture, no compensation will be given.

12. Conditions. Participation in Contest and/or acceptance of prize constitutes each winner's permission for Sponsor to use his/her name, address (city and state), likeness, photograph, picture, portrait, voice, biographical information, and/or any statements made by each winner regarding the Contest or Sponsor for advertising and promotional purposes without notice or additional compensation, except where prohibited by law. To the maximum extent permitted by law, by participating, entrants and winners agree to release and hold harmless Sponsor, and its advertising and promotion agencies and their respective parent companies, subsidiaries, affiliates, partners, legal

advisors, representatives, agents, successors, assigns, employees, officers and directors (collectively, “Released Entities”), from any and all liability, for loss, harm, damage, injury, cost or expense whatsoever including without limitation, property damage, personal injury and/or death which may occur in connection with, preparation for, travel to, or participation in Contest, or possession, acceptance and/or use or misuse of prize or participation in any Contest-related activity and for any claims based on publicity rights, defamation, invasion of privacy, copyright infringement, trademark infringement or any other intellectual property-related cause of action. Some jurisdictions do not allow (i) the exclusion of implied warranties on applicable statutory rights; (ii) limitations on a contracting party's liability with regards to damages or death caused due to its negligence or intentional misconduct, so the above exclusions and limitations may not apply in some cases. Entrants who do not comply with these Terms and Conditions or attempt to interfere with this Contest in any way shall be disqualified. Sponsor is not responsible if Contest cannot take place or if any prize cannot be awarded due to travel cancellations, delays or interruptions due to acts of God, acts of war, natural disasters, weather or acts of terrorism. Sponsor reserves the right, in its sole discretion, to cancel, terminate, modify, extend or suspend this Contest should (in its sole discretion) virus, bugs, non-authorized human intervention, fraud or other causes beyond its control corrupt or affect the administration, security, fairness or proper conduct of the Contest. In such case, Sponsor may select the winners from all eligible entries received before and/or after (if appropriate) the action taken by Sponsor.

13. Data Governance. As you collect data for your project, you’ll want to use [best practices](#). If you are provisioned or provided access to cloud or other IT services as part of this challenge, be sure that you read and understand the shared responsibility model associated with the IT services you are provided. Most services have a shared responsibility model, where the service handles some of the underlying aspects of security, while other aspects such as secure configuration, access control, and secure credential management are the responsibility of the user. Ensure that your challenge team has the necessary expertise and skills to keep cloud and AI services secure if you intend to undertake challenge efforts that will require the use of such services. Here are helpful tips:

- Data from public websites may be used, if the terms allow for commercial use, but please keep a list of the websites you use.
- Do not use IBM data or assets containing IBM Confidential data, or any other IBM data without permission from the IBM owner.
- Do not use any IBM client data.
- Do not use any data containing personal information (PI)
- Do not use data obtained from social media.
- All datasets should align with IBM values and principles. Avoid datasets that can be harmful to IBM (e.g., reputational risk, media risk, privacy, discrimination).

Should you wish to continue your project outside of this Challenge, following these tips should help avoid the need to start from scratch with new data.

14. Additional Terms. Any attempted form of entry other than as set forth above is prohibited. Any attempted form of entry including team cheating methods or similar means of entry are not permitted and can be considered a violation of IBM’s Business Conduct Guidelines and subject the entrant to disciplinary action, up to and including termination. To the maximum extent permitted by law, Released Entities are not responsible for technical, hardware, software, telephone or other communications malfunctions, errors or failures of any kind, lost or unavailable network connections, web site, Internet

or ISP availability, unauthorized human intervention, traffic congestion, incomplete or inaccurate capture of entry information (regardless of cause) or failed, incomplete, garbled, jumbled or delayed computer transmissions which may limit one's ability to enter the Contest, including any injury or damage to participant's or any other person's computer relating to or resulting from participating in this Contest or downloading any materials in this Contest. Sponsor reserves the right, at its sole discretion, to disqualify any individual it finds, in its sole discretion, to be tampering with the entry process or the operation of the Contest or web site. Sponsor may prohibit an entrant from participating in the Contest or winning a prize if, in its sole discretion, it determines that said entrant is attempting to undermine the legitimate operation of the Contest by cheating, hacking, deception, or other unfair playing practices (including the use of automated quick entry programs) or intending to annoy, abuse, threaten or harass any other entrants or Sponsor representatives.

CAUTION: ANY ATTEMPT BY AN ENTRANT TO DELIBERATELY DAMAGE ANY WEB SITE OR UNDERMINE THE LEGITIMATE OPERATION OF THE CONTEST MAY BE A VIOLATION OF CRIMINAL AND CIVIL LAWS AND SHOULD SUCH AN ATTEMPT BE MADE; THE SPONSOR RESERVES THE RIGHT TO SEEK DAMAGES FROM ANY SUCH PERSON TO THE FULLEST EXTENT PERMITTED BY LAW.

In the event of a dispute as to any entry, the authorized account holder of the email address used to enter will be deemed to be the entrant and must comply with these Terms and Conditions. The "authorized account holder" is the natural person assigned an email address by an Internet access provider, online service provider or other organization responsible for assigning email addresses for the domain associated with the submitted address. Each entrant may be required to show proof of being an authorized account holder.

15. Limitation of Liability; Disclaimer of Warranties. TO THE MAXIMUM EXTENT PERMITTED BY LAW, IN NO EVENT WILL THE RELEASED ENTITIES BE RESPONSIBLE OR LIABLE FOR ANY DAMAGES OR LOSSES OF ANY KIND, INCLUDING DIRECT, INDIRECT, INCIDENTAL, CONSEQUENTIAL OR PUNITIVE DAMAGES ARISING OUT OF YOUR ACCESS TO AND USE OF THE SITE AND/OR ENTRY IN THE CONTEST, DOWNLOADING FROM AND/OR PRINTING MATERIAL DOWNLOADED FROM ANY WEBSITES ASSOCIATED WITH THE CONTEST. WITHOUT LIMITING THE FOREGOING, THIS CONTEST AND ALL PRIZES ARE PROVIDED "AS IS" WITHOUT WARRANTY OF ANY KIND, EITHER EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO, THE IMPLIED WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY, FITNESS FOR A PARTICULAR PURPOSE OR NON-INFRINGEMENT. SOME JURISDICTIONS MAY NOT ALLOW THE LIMITATIONS OR EXCLUSION OF LIABILITY FOR INCIDENTAL OR CONSEQUENTIAL DAMAGES OR EXCLUSION OF IMPLIED WARRANTIES SO SOME OF THE ABOVE LIMITATIONS OR EXCLUSIONS MAY NOT APPLY TO YOU. CHECK YOUR LOCAL LAWS FOR ANY RESTRICTIONS OR LIMITATIONS REGARDING THESE LIMITATIONS OR EXCLUSIONS.

16. Governing Law. This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of New York, without regard to conflicts or choice of law rules or principles. You submit to the exclusive jurisdiction and venue of the federal or state courts of New York, County of Westchester, to resolve all issues that may arise out of or relate to this Agreement.

17. Privacy. Sponsor will be collecting personal data about entrants online, in accordance with its privacy policy. Please review the Sponsor's privacy policy at <https://w3.ibm.com/w3publisher/w3-privacy-notice>. By participating in the Contest, entrants hereby agree to Sponsor's collection and

usage of their personal information and acknowledge that they have read and accepted Sponsor's privacy policy.

18. List of Winners. To obtain a complete list of winners please visit: <https://w3.ibm.com/w3publisher/challenge> after September 5, 2026.

19. Miscellaneous. In the event of any conflict between the English version of these Terms and Conditions and any translation, the English version shall prevail. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision herein shall not affect in any way the validity and enforceability of any other provision in these Terms and Conditions. If any provision of these Terms and Conditions are or become partially void or are held to be invalid or unenforceable in any respect, the parties will continue to be bound by the remaining Terms and Conditions, which shall be enforced to the full extent permitted by law. Furthermore, entrants agree that the parties shall replace the voided or invalid parts by provisions that are valid and have legal effect that correspond with those of such voided or invalid parts as much as possible, taking into account the content and the purpose of these Terms and Conditions. IN THE EVENT THERE IS A DISCREPANCY OR INCONSISTENCY BETWEEN DISCLOSURES OR OTHER STATEMENTS CONTAINED IN ANY CONTEST MATERIALS AND THESE TERMS AND CONDITIONS, THE TERMS AND CONDITIONS SHALL PREVAIL, GOVERN AND CONTROL.